

Carried away

Plants spread their seeds so they can grow in new places. This is called seed dispersal. It gives the seeds a chance to find sunlight, water, and food that are not already being used by the parent plant or by other seeds.

The pod pushes the seeds forward.

A flying start

Impatiens are a group of garden plants sometimes called “touch-me-nots”. Their seed pods are ready to burst at the slightest touch. Seeds are flung out, although they don’t travel far.

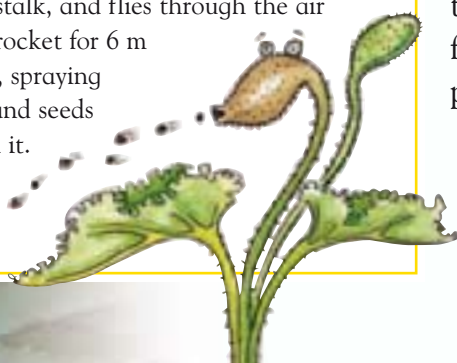


Get stuck in

Have you ever let a pet dog run in fields? It might have come back with burrs in its fur. Burrs are seeds with sticky or spiky coats that grip animal fur, later falling off onto new ground.

SPIT OUT THE SEEDS

The Mediterranean squirting cucumber has a messy method of seed dispersal. As it grows, each cucumber fruit fills with slime until there’s no more room. Then, suddenly... POP! The fruit bursts, comes off its stalk, and flies through the air like a rocket for 6 m (20 ft), spraying slime and seeds behind it.



Just passing through

Fruit is tasty and colourful to get animals to eat it. Animals swallow seeds with the fruit. When the seeds have passed through the animal, they are far away from the parent plant.

